strategic cowardice on their part, a piece of work, indeed, and one that is so ingrained in that paper's self-protective sense of itself that they likely can't even see it. They dressed it up as caution and responsibility: they wanted the stories, had been working for weeks on the stories, but didn't have the balls to go out there and run it first. They wanted WikiLeaks to go first, which, we now see, was part of their strategy – to hide behind this 'maverick' outfit whose story they were just 'reflecting'. Bill Keller, the editor, could puff himself up with self-belief, but in fact he did not have the courage of his journalistic convictions, was fearful of the Pentagon, and he did what a six-year-old playground swot would be decried for doing, and hid behind the coat-tails of the school's bad boy while scoffing the spoils of the tuckshop. It would be painful to watch them, once the material was bagged, to stray and spew their guts up, never ready to stand up for the part they had played in partnering us. The cock crowed three times, and Bill Keller shamelessly denied us, throwing in a few volleys of personal abuse to keep himself clean.

Disgusting. But a smarter media player than me would certainly have seen it coming. Being first is everything in journalism, but here was the biggest newspaper in the world asking point-blank to go second. Keller's cowardice will be his lasting legacy: for these cables reveal terrible events in Afghanistan, and a stronger man, a better journalist, would have leapt to add his paper's imprimatur to the truth they revealed. Instead, he played it safe and let us take it on the chin, which, of course, we are always ready to do, anyway. But by that point I was a bag-lady and a smelly old nutcase, according to him, while he was Bill Keller, the weakest and most self-protecting man ever to edit the *New York Times*. Infamy comes in many guises, and sometimes, even, it comes wearing a sports jacket and an old school tie, asking us to forgive him what he does, for he only does it in the name of propriety. Next to Ben Bradlee, who stood by his two maverick reporters during Watergate, or Robert West and Gobin Stair of Beacon Press, who were subpoenaed and would have gone to jail rather than sell out Daniel Ellsberg over the Pentagon Papers, this man is a moral pygmy with a self-justifying streak the size of the San Andreas Fault. WikiLeaks, a small, not-for-profit Web start-up, would be standing alone as usual at the last post.

Coincidentally (or not), all the ducks we had spent months lining up began to quack with self-interest when the hour came. Thirty-six hours